PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

Fort Sumter — A House Divided

How a Food Shipment Started a War

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about Fort Sumter — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. Big events rarely have one cause. Trace the chain of decisions that led from a hungry fort to a nation at war

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · APRIL 1861 — The Bombardment of Fort Sumter



No soldier was killed in the 34-hour bombardment itself — yet this was the spark that lit four years of the bloodiest war in American history

"Bombardment of Fort Sumter, Charleston Harbor, April 12 & 13, 1861" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1861, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · A NORTHERN NEWSPAPER · APRIL 1861 — The reaction in the North

"The heather is on fire. … The attack upon Fort Sumter has made the North a unit. … Party is forgotten; every man is for his country."
— widely reprinted Northern editorial, April 1861. Public domain

— widely reprinted Northern editorial, April 1861. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · BUILD THE CHAIN

Put these five events in the correct order by numbering them 1–5: (a) four more states secede · (b) Lincoln sends food to the fort · (c) Lincoln calls for 75,000 volunteers · (d) the fort runs low on supplies · (e) the Confederacy bombards the fort.

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · THE CLEVER TRAP

Lincoln announced he was sending only food — no weapons or troops. Why was this such a shrewd move?

- ☐ A. it secretly smuggled weapons into the fort
- ☐ B. it guaranteed the war would never happen
- ☐ C. it forced the Confederacy to choose between backing down or firing the first shot
- ☐ D. it convinced the seceded states to rejoin the Union

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · EFFECTS RIPPLE OUT

After Sumter, Lincoln called for 75,000 volunteers — and four more states seceded in response. Explain the cause and effect: why did a call for troops push states like Virginia out of the Union?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · MAKE THE JUDGMENT

Historians still argue about Sumter. Did Lincoln cleverly maneuver the South into starting the war, or did he provoke a war he could have avoided? Take a side and defend it in two or three sentences, using the chain of events as evidence.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — Fort Sumter — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "1 = ___ 2 = ___ 3 = ___ 4 = ___ 5 = ___"

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. it forced the Confederacy to choose between backing down or firing the first shot**

Exactly. By offering only food, Lincoln made the Confederacy choose between looking weak or firing on a humanitarian shipment. Either way, the hard choice — and the blame for starting the war — landed on them.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The call for troops forced states to choose because..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I think Lincoln ___ because the sequence of events shows..."